

General Knowledge

Indian Polity

STUDY NOTES

Parliamentary Committees

PREAMBLE
PEOPLE OF INDIA, do hereby



PARLIAMENTARY COMMITTEES

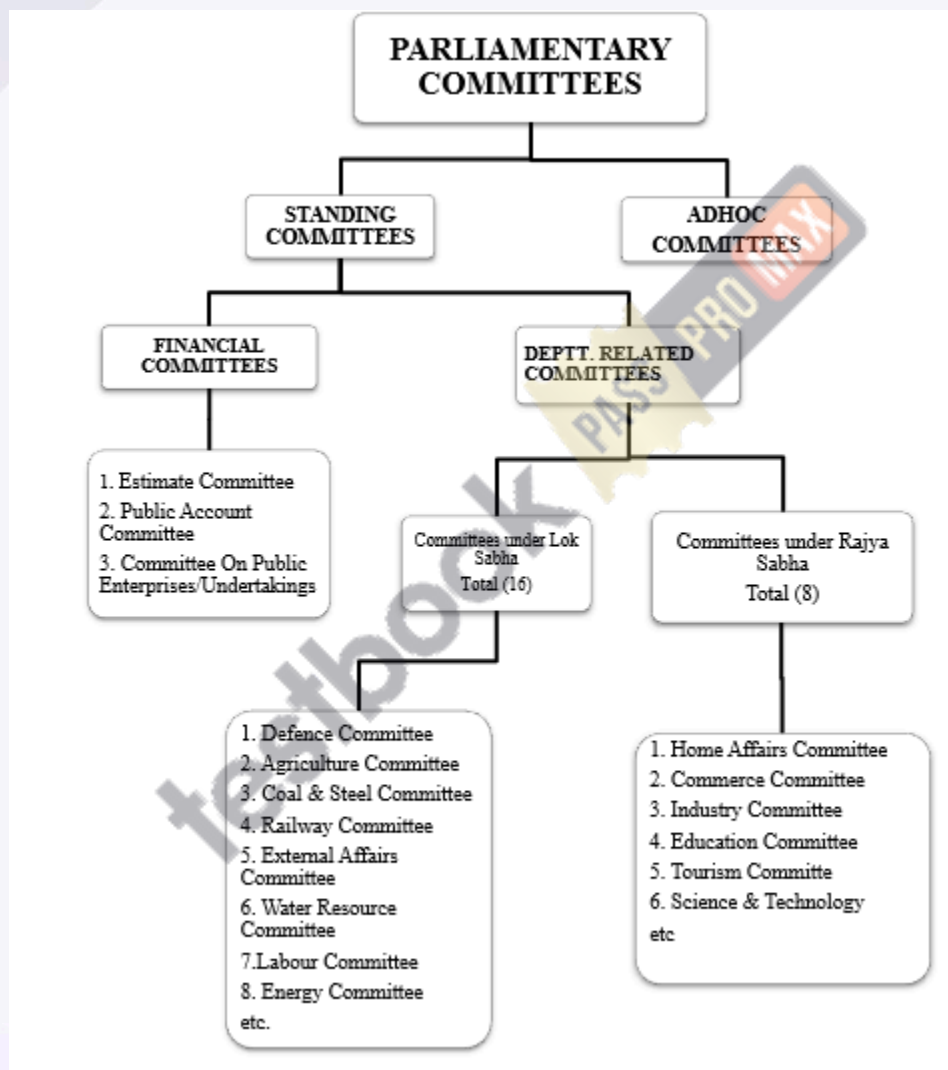


Introduction:

- **Parliamentary Committees** are bodies formed to manage the vast, complex, and varied functions of the **Parliament of India**. They play a crucial role in scrutinizing and assisting in the legislative and administrative tasks of Parliament.
- These committees are essential for **effective governance**, helping manage the high volume of legislative work that would be difficult for Parliament alone.
- The **Constitution of India** mentions these committees, but does not provide specific details on their structure, composition, or tenure; these are governed by the **rules of each House**.
- A **parliamentary committee** is either appointed or elected by the **House of Parliament** and reports directly to it, working under the **guidance of the Speaker or Chairman**.
- Broadly, parliamentary committees are classified into two main categories: **Standing Committees** (permanent) and **Ad Hoc Committees** (temporary).

- The **financial, administrative, and procedural checks** provided by these committees ensure a balance of power and accountability.
- They enhance **executive accountability** by examining reports, budgets, and government policies in detail.

Detailed Explanation of Parliamentary Committees



Types of Parliamentary Committees

- **Standing Committees:**
 - These are **permanent committees** reconstituted annually or periodically, and they work on a continuous basis. Standing Committees are further classified based on their functions:

- **Financial Committees:**

- Deal with financial matters, ensuring accountability in government expenditure and financial policies.

1. **Public Accounts Committee (PAC):**

- Established in **1921** under the **Government of India Act, of 1919**.
- Comprises **22 members** (15 from Lok Sabha and 7 from Rajya Sabha) who examine reports of the **Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG)**.
- Focuses on public spending efficiency, examining irregularities and ensuring funds are used prudently.

2. **Estimates Committee:**

- Created in **1950** on the recommendation of **John Mathai**, former Finance Minister.
- Consists solely of **Lok Sabha members** (30 in total) and examines budget estimates to suggest economies and improvements.

3. **Committee on Public Undertakings:**

- Established in **1964** on the recommendation of the **Krishna Menon Committee**.
- Examines accounts of public enterprises and ensures they operate efficiently and in line with business principles.

- **Departmental Standing Committees (DRSCs):**

- Formed in **1993** to ensure **financial accountability** of each ministry, focusing on **detailed examination of policies and bills**.
- There are **24 DRSCs** covering various ministries, consisting of **31 members** each (21 from Lok Sabha and 10 from Rajya Sabha).

- **Committees to Inquire:**

- Focused on examining specific issues within Parliament or involving public interest.
 - **Committee on Petitions:** Deals with petitions on bills or public matters; consists of **15 members** in Lok Sabha and **10 in Rajya Sabha**.
 - **Committee of Privileges:** Handles breaches of parliamentary privileges.
 - **Ethics Committee:** Enforces the code of conduct, maintaining discipline among members.

- **Committees to Scrutinize and Control:**

- Review administrative functions and ensure government commitments are fulfilled.

- **Committee on Government Assurances:** Reviews promises made by ministers in the House.
- **Committee on Subordinate Legislation:** Ensures delegated legislation aligns with the powers given by Parliament.
- **Committee on Papers Laid on the Table:** Examines compliance of papers presented in the House.
- **Committees Relating to the Day-to-Day Business of the House:**
 - Manage the regular activities and procedures of Parliament.
 - **Business Advisory Committee:** Allocates time for legislative business.
 - **Committee on Private Members' Bills and Resolutions:** Assigns time for discussions on private members' bills.
 - **Rules Committee:** Suggests changes to parliamentary rules and procedures.
- **House-Keeping Committees (Service Committees):**
 - Ensure facilities and services for Parliament members.
 - **General Purposes Committee:** Advises on issues not covered by other committees.
 - **House Committee:** Manages accommodations for members.
 - **Library Committee:** Ensures optimal use of parliamentary library resources.
- **Ad Hoc Committees:**
 - Temporary committees constituted for a specific purpose or task. They dissolve after completing their assigned work.
 - **Inquiry Committees:**
 - Formed to investigate and report on particular subjects.
 - Examples include **Committee on MPLADS** and **Joint Committee on Security in Parliament Complex**.
 - **Advisory Committees (Select and Joint Committees on Bills):**
 - Review bills in detail, considering clauses and provisions. Select Committees involve one House, while Joint Committees include members from both Houses.

Key Parliamentary Committees in Detail

- **Public Accounts Committee (PAC):**

- Examines the **CAG's audit reports** on government spending and checks for irregularities, waste, and extravagance in public spending.
- Acts as a post-mortem body, meaning it reviews expenditure after it has been incurred.
- Limitations include advisory-only powers; recommendations are not binding on ministries.
- **Estimates Committee:**
 - Analyzes budget estimates and suggests ways to reduce government expenditure, improve efficiency, and enhance administrative reforms.
 - Limited to examining selected ministries each year, and does not have the technical support of CAG as PAC does.
- **Committee on Public Undertakings:**
 - Scrutinizes financial and operational efficiency of public sector enterprises, ensuring adherence to sound business practices.
 - Cannot intervene in matters of policy or day-to-day administration.
- **Departmental Standing Committees (DRSCs):**
 - Examine budget allocations and policies of ministries to ensure accountability.
 - Their recommendations are not binding, but they improve executive accountability and provide expert insights into various sectors.

Committee	Ministries/Departments Covered
I. Committees under Rajya Sabha	
Committee on Commerce	Commerce and Industry
Committee on Home Affairs	Home Affairs, Development of North-Eastern Region
Committee on Human Resource Development	Human Resource Development, Youth Affairs and Sports, Women and Child Development
Committee on Industry	Heavy Industries and Public Enterprises, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
Committee on Science & Technology	Science and Technology, Space, Earth Sciences, Atomic Energy, Environment, Forests, and Climate Change

Committee on Transport, Tourism & Culture	Civil Aviation, Road Transport & Highways, Shipping, Culture, Tourism
Committee on Health & Family Welfare	Health and Family Welfare, Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha and Homeopathy (AYUSH)
Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law & Justice	Law and Justice, Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions
II. Committees under Lok Sabha	
Committee on Agriculture	Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare, Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, Food Processing Industries
Committee on Information Technology	Communication, Electronics & Information Technology, Information & Broadcasting
Committee on Defence	Defence
Committee on Energy	New and Renewable Energy, Power
Committee on External Affairs	External Affairs
Committee on Finance	Finance, Corporate Affairs, Planning, Statistics and Programme Implementation
Committee on Food, Consumer Affairs & Public Distribution	Consumer Affairs, Food, and Public Distribution
Committee on Labour	Labour & Employment, Skill Development & Entrepreneurship, Textiles
Committee on Petroleum & Natural Gas	Petroleum and Natural Gas
Committee on Railways	Railways
Committee on Urban Development	Housing and Urban Affairs
Committee on Water Resources	Jal Shakti

Committee on Chemicals and Fertilizers	Chemicals and Fertilizers
Committee on Rural Development	Rural Development, Panchayati Raj
Committee on Coal and Steel	Coal, Mines, Steel
Committee on Social Justice and Empowerment	Social Justice and Empowerment, Tribal Affairs, Minority Affairs

Functions and Significance of Parliamentary Committees:

- **Detailed Examination:** Committees allow for a thorough examination of policies, budgets, and bills, providing a level of scrutiny not feasible in full House discussions.
- **Executive Accountability:** They hold the government accountable by reviewing its actions and suggesting improvements.
- **Expertise and Efficiency:** By involving members with knowledge of particular sectors, committees bring expertise to the legislative process.
- **Continuous Monitoring:** Standing Committees provide ongoing oversight of government functions and finances, ensuring a balance of power.

Limitations of Parliamentary Committees:

- **Advisory Nature:** Most committee recommendations are not binding, limiting their power to enforce decisions.
- **Lack of Time and Resources:** Some committees cannot address every issue due to time constraints and lack of technical resources.
- **Focus on Post-Mortem Analysis:** Financial committees like PAC conduct a review after spending, rather than preemptive oversight.

Points to Remember:

1. **Standing Committees** are permanent, while **Ad Hoc Committees** are temporary.
2. **Financial Committees** such as the **Public Accounts Committee (PAC)**, **Estimates Committee**, and **Committee on Public Undertakings** focus on financial accountability.
3. **Departmental Standing Committees (DRSCs)** cover all ministries and review bills, demands for grants, and policies.

4. **Inquiring Committees** like the **Ethics Committee** and **Committee on Petitions** handle specific issues of public and parliamentary importance.
5. **Consultative Committees** provide a forum for interaction but are not considered parliamentary committees.
6. **Committees to Scrutinize and Control** ensure government accountability in legislative commitments and rule-making authority.